Bradley Allen

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A History of Stereotypes in *South Pacific*, *The King and I*, and *Flower Drum Song*

Psychologist Robert Baron famously conducted a study on prosocial behavior finding participants were more helpful "in the presence of pleasant fragrances" such as Mrs. Field's Cookies and roast coffee "than in their absence" (498). With this study, Baron showed the environment can subconsciously affect a person's behavior. This finding is useful to understand the employment of Asian American stereotypes by Rodgers and Hammerstein in their plays *South Pacific*, *The King and I*, and *Flower Drum Song*. Historians and researchers argue that U.S. foreign policies such as containment of communism and integration of Asian markets created a culture in which Asian Americans were presented to white audiences as *exotic*, *hyper sexualized*, *barbaric*, and in need of Western education. With the scent of these policies in the air, Rodgers and Hammerstein created three extremely popular plays that perpetuated stereotypes of Asian Americans that have endured to this day.

Twin Soliloquies: Containment and Integration

In "Cold War Orientalism," author Christina Klein argues US foreign policy in the late 1940s led to framing Asians as socially separable but economically integral. Klein writes that anxiety over Soviet expansion in the latter half of the 20th century was expressed in the "Truman Doctrine" of 1947, wherein US foreign policy would take on "a global imaginary of containment" of all countries communist (23). Global imaginary is a term coined by Manfred Steger, Professor of Sociology at the University of Hawai'i, which he describes as "the messy superimposition of the global village on the conventional nation-state." That is, how "political

leaders and business elites" residing in "privileged spaces" reconcile "national boundaries in search of their piece of global promise" (Steger). Klein's plaiting the global imaginary and containment is shorthand for Truman attempting to balance U.S. economic superiority while preventing the spread of communism.

Pursuit of containment and integration resulted in a mix of dollar diplomacy and a cultural paradox. "Americans have always understood their democratic political freedoms to be inseparable from their economic ones" observes Klein (24), and this was especially true in Asia. In the late 19th century, U.S. economic policy guided its foreign policy, according to Klein, leading the U.S. to "acquire a territorial empire in the Pacific" through the annexation of "the Midway Islands in 1867, Samoa in 1878, Hawaii, Guam, and the Philippines in 1898" and, finally, "Wake Island in 1899" (25). Klein asserts that U.S. economic conquest in Asia culminated in a sort-of free-trade imperialism from 1899 to 1900 where Washington "issued the 'open door' notes to China and extended it in the 1920s under the rubric of 'dollar diplomacy'" (25). In other words, the U.S. wanted access to Asian markets and was willing to assert its authority to achieve its goals.

As communism spread to Asia post-World War II, the U.S. turned to Broadway to convince Americans that Asians were separate but integral. "[A]ny [restriction] on U.S. economic growth – such as those posed by communist government – were seen as a threat to … 'the American way of life'," says Klein (25). Problematically, "Washington concluded … expanding the capitalist system of free trade on a global scale" meant "The creation of this integrated global economy" (25). Convincing Americans to accept conflicting policies of containment and integration required winning the minds of the public.

The quickest way to one's mind is through the eyes. "[S]pectators watching a performance will connect their experience" to a "culturally significant image" argues Bruce McConachie, in a review of Rodgers and Hammerstein's "Oriental" musicals for *Theater Journal* (387). "When this occurs" he continues, "audiences understand the performances as a potent symbol of their cultural orientation, an imitation of their way of life" (387). McConachie's argument is based on his review of work by cognitive psychologists George Lakoff and Mark Johnson. Their work, according to McConachie, suggests that playwrights like Rogers and Hammerstein use "a cluster of metaphors" that structure "certain events in our experience as a narrative" that "emerge as central in the minds of most audience members" (386, 387). These narratives assume a structure of "source-path-goal" that "humans know kinesthetically at an early age by moving from a starting point to an end point" (386). Taken together, McConachie's argument suggests playwrights employ metaphors to reduce discomfort of cultural differences and contain them within an existing narrative.

Carefully Taught

The "container" metaphor claims McConachie, "shaped much of white, middle-class America's perception of the world" (387). The "psycho-social consequences of the container metaphor" supplied Americans with a "conception of the world as an ongoing conflict between insiders and outsiders" rendering "Communists … the psychological Other" (McConachie 388). To illustrate the employment of containment, McConachie points to circumstances leading up to the Vietnam War where, "For containment and the war to make cognitive sense, the South Vietnamese had to be much like us under the skin" (388). To accomplish this task, McConachie refers to the historian James William Gibson, who dubbed "U.S. foreign policy during the 1950s 'mechanistic anticommunism' because of its reliance on metaphors of lifeless machinery" (388).

McConachie's central claim here is that the U.S. government's containment leveraged entertainment to create a sense of good vs evil – those *like us under the skin* vs the machinery of communism – that Americans could internalize as an *us vs them* narrative. "These metaphors" concludes McConachie, "structured much of the enjoyment of Rodgers and Hammerstein's 'oriental' musicals for Americans from the late 1940s through the 1950s" (389).

This includes *South Pacific*, *The King and I*, and *Flower Drum Song* (Klein 14). To highlight the popularity of these plays, the original Broadway productions alone netted Rodgers and Hammerstein one Pulitzer Prize for Drama and sixteen Tony Awards ("South Pacific - 1949"; "The King and I - 1951"; "Flower Drum Song - 1958"). "Extraordinarily popular and widely circulated" Klein says these plays were emblematic of "the postwar fascination with Asia" whose "themes, styles, and attitudes … are representative of a larger body of middlebrow texts produced about Asia" (14). Klein describes the middlebrow intellectual as "sophisticated intellectuals for the 1940s and 1950s" who presented the Cold War as "activities in which [ordinary Americans] could invest their emotional and intellectual energy" (14). Producing entertainment that brought the U.S.-Asia alliance "to life by translating [it] into personal terms and imbuing [it] with sentiment" was the middlebrow intellectual's means of delivering "emotionally rich" cultural tourism in which (white) Americans "could inhabit imaginatively in their everyday lives" (14). For Rodgers and Hammerstein, this meant employing "white ethnic narratives" in their plays to "ease" (white) American audiences into the Asian experience (177).

This was particularly the case in *Flower Drum Song*. *Flower Drum Song* was the first major Broadway play that "told an Asian American story … using Asian American actors" (Klein 179). Despite "Rodgers and Hammerstein's mild brand of liberal antiracism," their work was "seen as inadequate and outdated" (Klein 178). Klein quotes Rodgers in a *Newsweek* article

from 1958, where he described the goal of *Flower Drum Song* as showing the "East and West can get together with a little adjustment" (178). These adjustments, according to Klein, were received by critics as "recycling … conventions of earlier white ethnic narratives" (178). Such narratives stem from *The King and I* and *South Pacific*, which were produced seven and nine years before *Flower Drum Song*, respectively. According to McConachie, these narratives separated the people from their communist governments: "the Tonkonese, Siamese, and American Chinese are just like 'us,' … good people, yearning to free themselves from external oppression" (397), allowing "Americans to cloak their racism as benevolence" (397).

This narrative is evident in the song "Chop Suey," which is described by Klein as Hammerstein's "metaphor for an ethnically and culturally diverse America" (177). To setup the song in the film, Madam Liang, who just earned her American citizenship, says "I am happy to be both Chinese and American," to which Master Wang Chi-Yang responds, "You are like the Chinese dish the Americans invented. What do they call it?" asks Chi-Yang, "Chop Suey" replies his son, "That is it. Everything is in it, all mixed up" he rejoins (*Flower Drum Song*, 56:58-57:09). Poetically, Juanita Hall, the actress who portrayed Madam Liang, was not Asian. Klein quotes a review in *Variety* magazine that described the bit as "'distasteful' and unlikely to amuse Chinese audiences" because it asks them to "note 'how darling' or 'how precious' it is of them to undertake the execution of American dances" (178). Ethnically diverse and critically rejected for it, "Chop Suey" also highlights the tension between containment and integration: How to categorize Asian American actors.

Flower Drum Song presented reviewers with a conundrum: Do they refer to Asian Americans as American or by their national heritage? The popularity of *Flower Drum Song* meant that "Chinese Americans [were] visible as ethnic Americans" rather than "an alien

'yellow-peril' threat" and it was left to reviewers and producers to figure out how to write about the cast (Klein 179). Programs were inconsistent, identifying actors "in terms of their ethnic mix, their immigrant origins, and their place of birth" rather than "noting each actor's previous stage work" (Klein 180). For example, Klein points out that one actor was identified by the origin of his parents as "Californians of Japanese birth and American citizenship" while others explained that "some actors had changed their names – from the Japanese Goro Suzuki to the Chinese-sounding Jack Soo" which was done to avoid "anti-Japanese racism" (Klein 180). Containment meant prefixing actors by their heritage, while integration meant suffixing some indicator that these people were also American; therefore, their stories were safe to explore.

Pursuing competing policies of containment and integration required threading an ethnic needle with a narrative of white-woven thread. The U.S. government wanted to contain communism. Businesses wanted access to Asian markets. The American public needed entertainment to carefully teach them the mental gymnastics required when holding two conflicting ideas at the same time. Rodgers and Hammerstein filled that need with their trio of "Oriental" musicals. Operating within an ethnically separable but economically integral framework required a vehicle. Reviewers of their plays argue exoticism was the vehicle.

Separate but Exotic

In 2021, researchers published an article in the *Journal of Women and Social Work* titled "'You're So Exotic Looking': An Intersectional Analysis of Asian American and Pacific Islander Stereotypes." Their goal was to analyze data from Twitter "to understand the concurrently racialized, gendered, and sexualized experiences of APIs [Asian American Pacific Islanders]" during a social movement labeled "#thisis2016" (Azhar et al. 283). Through thematic analysis using "critical race theory's concept of intersectionality," the authors found that "API women are

perceived to be exotic and overly sexualized" and were "expected to be passive" and, in general, "APIs are the subjects of neocolonist attitudes" (Azhar et al. 282). According to researcher Guanhua Wen, the "hyper-sexualization" of Asian American Women can be "traced all the way back to Western imperialism during the World War II Era and the Proxy Wars" (192). Rodgers and Hammerstein's "Oriental" musicals, produced during this period, employed these themes.

Seen but not heard: The tale of exotic Liat in *South Pacific*. To understand Liat, one must first understand the Page Act. Passed in 1875 and repealed in 1974, the "Page Act forbade the 'importation' of women into the United States 'for the purposes of prostitution'" and gave immigration authorities "full authority to determine whether an Asian woman was being trafficked for 'lewd and immoral purposes'" (Hijar). Wen notes that the Page Act originated the "association of Asian American females with prostitution and the sex industry" (193). Liat's character may well have been cut and pasted from the Page Act into *South Pacific*. Bloody Mary, the mother of Liat, "only wants to make a quick buck" selling "shrunken human heads; she also sells her daughter to the 'saxy Lootellan' Cable" (Most 314). Mary and Liat are representations of what Andrea Most, writing for *Theater Journal*, describes as "one-dimensional" Asian characters "largely without agency" who "live in an exotic paradise called Bali Hai" (313). Liat's importation to America is symbolized by her "relationship" with Cable: a sexualized, exotic Asian woman up for sale to an American in a faraway and equally exotic land.

If this sounds like a familiar stereotype, it should. Azhar and colleagues' description of the stereotype of API women could well be a review of Liat: "exotic," "hypersexualized," and "passive" (282). Presented as "beautiful, docile, exotic, and willing," Liat has no speaking lines (Most314). Instead, according to the stage directions of *South Pacific*, Liat is described as "small, yellow, with Oriental eyes" and is to be known for her "shrill cackle" (as cited in

Most314). This plays out in the song "Happy Talk," where Liat, according to the stage directions, "performs a gentle, childish dance" silently and smilingly (as cited in Most 315). "The effect is that of a literal dumb show" writes Most (315). To be fair, "Exotic sexual objects are not supposed to have complex thoughts" writes Most, chiding Rodgers and Hammerstein's decision to "withhold the tools – a voice, a song – Liat needs to function as a real character in a musical" (315). More problematic than a racial stereotype was the prospect of a functional relationship between Cable and Liat.

Produced in a time when interracial marriage was an act of miscegenation, the relationship between Cable and Liat was not to be. From 1691 until the Supreme Court decided Loving v. Virginia in 1967, "Anti-miscegenation laws were established … to criminalize interracial dating and marriage" in the U.S. (Supreme Court Historical Society). A product of its time, *South Pacific* was first performed on Broadway in 1949, was culturally beholden to the dictates of these laws. "Rodgers and Hammerstein would have been openly and powerfully advocating miscegenation" were they to give Liat, a "racial other both a voice and a blue-blooded American man for a husband" asserts Most (317). In the play, Cable breaks off the relationship because he and Liat are racially incompatible and is "killed off as soon as he realizes the problematic nature of his own behavior," observes Most, who concludes "Death is the neatest and easiest solution" to prevent miscegenation from playing out in front of American audiences (317). If exoticism was the vehicle, stereotype was the driver Rodgers and Hammerstein used to play with the concept of integration, and killing Cable off before an act of miscegenation occurred was a form of containment, a metaphor spelling *separate but exotic*.

In Love with a Wonderful Stereotype

The relationship between Liat and Cable was not the last to be governed by containment and integration. Consider the relationship between Nellie and Emile in *South Pacific*. "Emile evokes the European … intellectuals who fled to America … to escape Nazi persecution" who was given "an apparent advantage by making him 'cultured' and Nellie a 'hick'" (Most 325). According to Most, Emile's "antifascist background immediately raises a red flag" at a time of "competing anxieties about the racial, cultural, and political world of the late 1940s" (325, 326). To dispel anxiety, Rodgers and Hammerstein have "Nellie self-consciously imitate the stance of a HUAC cross examiner" as she questions Emile about his past, as "Foreigners, especially those with strident antifascist backgrounds … might after all be communists" (Most 327). To put audiences at ease, "Emile responds to Nellie's inquiries by asserting his belief in the fundamental American ideals of freedom and equality" (Most329). If killing Cable prevented anxiety over an act of miscegenation, it seems vetting Emile for American ideals was necessary to allow his relationship with Nellie to proceed. That is, right up until it became racial.

According to Most, "Emile becomes the sounding board for American racial angst" when Nellie "breaks off [their] engagement" after discovering he was once romantically involved with a "Polynesian woman." Echoing Cable, the fact that Emile fathered children with a Polynesian woman prohibits a relationship with Nellie. "It means that I can't marry you" explains Nellie, "I can't help it. It isn't as if I could give you a good reason," she continues, "This is something born in me" (as cited in Most329). As the play progresses, Emile embarks on a mission for the military where he goes missing in action. Distraught, Nellie sees the error of her ways, and moves into Emile's plantation home to care for his children until he returns ("South Pacific - 1949"). When Emile returns, he finds Nellie singing a song with his children. To announce his

return, Emile joins in. "So powerful is Emile that in the final moment of the play, he renders Nellie, the star speechless," writes Most (337).

Such an ending, argues Most, exploits "Emile's European high-culture" to "end up overwhelming Nellie's popular American style" (337). If Nellie's relationship with Emile is dirtied by his relationship with a Polynesian woman, it's the sort of dirt that washes off because he is a white European who only fathered Polynesian children. Unlike Cable, Emile's European heritage, it seems, precluded him from an act of miscegenation, thus making it acceptable for him to be with Nellie. On the one hand, Cable's relationship with a stereotype required him to be killed off. Nellie's relationship with Emille, on the other hand, was permissible because she was in love with a wonderful stereotype.

Whistle a Happy Tune, Intrepid Educator!

Beyond hyper sexualized stereotypes – but in keeping with containment and integration – was the role of the Western educator in Rodgers and Hammerstein's "Oriental" musicals. In *The King and I*, this role was filled by Anna Leonowens. Writing for *Theater Journal*, Bruce McConachie argues Rodgers and Hammerstein's "'Oriental' Musicals" applied "Newtonian-like mechanics to social problems" by inviting "audiences to join the entailments of containment" of the "other" and chief among these mechanics being "the enabling power of education" (385, 394). McConachie highlights the role of education in each play, beginning with *Flower Drum Song*, which "traces the education of Mei Li" who adapts performances from Western "television … to find a solution to her marital problems" (394). In *South Pacific*, "Lieutenant Cable's 'carefully taught' racism can be reversed through proper education" while Nellie "learns tolerance" from Emille and pledges to raise his children with "humanistic understanding" (394). But the role of educator and pupil was most salient in *The King and I*.

Hired to educate the children of Siam, Anna Leonowen teaches the "barbaric" King of Siam Western civility to "impress … British delegates," preventing a hostile takeover of Siam (McConachie 392). "Early in the action of *The King and I*, Anna gives the King's children a lesson in geopolitics" when she covers an old map where "Siam occupies an area roughly the size of China" with one showing "Siam reduced to dimensions" and "colored to denote the encroachments of European imperial power" (McConachie 385). Upset by the diminished size of Siam, the children protest, but the King "commands them to recognize Anna's version of the world is the correct one" (McConachie 385). McConachie likens this scene to a brand of American foreign policy held by Henry Kissinger, who held that "Without the aid of western advisors … the people of Southeast Asia could not understand their lives and their place in the world" (385). McConachie concludes that, like Kissinger, "Rodgers and Hammerstein assumed that the West had a monopoly on knowing reality" (385).

Through a series of modernizing lessons like the map scene, Anna saves Siam from British conquest. As Anna attempts to educate the King and his children, the British are working behind the scenes to ensure Siam is "the next domino likely to fall in Southeast Asia" an event that will "confirm British hegemony in the region" (McConachie 396). To prevent this, Anna conveys to the King that the "English will be impressed by the façade of civilization" where "she helps the king to 'dress up' his wives" in "European fashion" and put on a Siamese "production of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*" (McConachie 391). The play, dubbed "The Little House of Uncle Thomas" by the Siamese, is meant to both impress the British and educate the King "with its subtext of emancipation" by "forcefully [arguing for] the superiority of balanced contractual agreements over tyrannical power" (McConachie 395). The adherence to contractual agreements is argued to be Rodgers and Hammerstein's nod to capitalism, as "Anna's struggle with the King

hinges on his unwillingness to keep his promises" and, as McConachie observes, "promise-making and promise-keeping … was fundamental to the development of capitalism in the West" (395). All that remains is for the King to see if the façade pays off.

Fortunately for the King, Anna's efforts persuade the British to leave the King in control of Siam. The "counterforce of modernization" writes McConachie, is a "stronger mechanism" than the manifest destiny of British control over the East, thus preventing "the toppling of the Siamese domino" (396). McConachie concludes that "Education that lays the basis for capitalistic development" was received by American audiences as preventing one more Asian country from "turning pink" (396). In the song ,"I Whistle a Happy Tune," Anna touts her skills of "deception" by convincing others she is "brave" when she whistles a "happy tune," telling her son deception will "take you far" (Hammerstein II). Anna, the intrepid educator, whistled her way into saving Siam from British take over. Rodgers and Hammerstein, meanwhile, leveraged their "popular musicals … to convince American citizens to support U.S. policies in Southeast Asia in the 1960s" (McConachie 398).

This Nearly Was Theirs

Rodgers and Hammerstein have been roundly criticized for their employment of stereotypes, but it would be a mistake to conclude a legacy of racism was their cross to bear. "[A]rtists like Rodgers and Hammerstein … had a personal stake in asserting [a] connection between anticommunism and civil rights" argues Most (309). According to Most, Rodgers and Hammerstein faced political pressure to play up stereotypes as even the "antiracism" message of *South Pacific* was "equated" to "pro-communism and … implied that the New York … theater was receiving its direction from Moscow," hence Rodgers and Hammerstein "needed to dissociate … from communism and establish their own anticommunist message" (309).

"Antiracism thus became both a Cold War liability and a Cold War imperative, a mark of lingering leftist commitments" concurs Klein (37).

These pressures were complicated by Rodgers and Hammerstein's Jewish heritage. "Many assimilated Jews worried that the 'rooting out' of communist subversives was tinged antisemitism" and this included Rodgers and Hammerstein (Most 328). Rodgers, "like many others, felt threatened that his Jewishness would be conflated with communist sympathies" writes Most (328). Running the risk of being associated with communism, Rodgers and Hammerstein still "sought to avoid overt racism of theatrical productions featuring Asians" says McConachie (397). He points out a quote from Hammerstein who said, "I did not want to tread on any Oriental toes" thus he consciously avoided "girls dressed in Oriental costumes and dancing out onto the stage and singing 'ching-aling-aling' with their fingers in the air" (as cited in McConachie 397). Perhaps this explains why Liat's performance of "Happy Talk" was a "dumb show" as Most pointed out (315). Nevertheless, fear of anticommunist retribution against Jews was deadly serious.

The same year *The King and I* debuted on Broadway, another Jewish spectacle concluded. That was the trial of Julius and Ethel Rosenberg. The trial, which began on March 6, 1951 and concluded on March 29, "found guilty" the Rosenbergs, who "were charged with conspiracy to commit espionage," a crime described by the presiding judge, Irving Kaufman, as "worse than murder" (Jenkins and Britannica Editors). The trial has historically been considered "delegitimized as an antisemitic charade" and the prosecutors, Irving Saypol and Roy Cohn, who themselves were Jewish, were accused of proving "themselves to be 'loyal' American Jews" by "earning reputations for successfully prosecuting communists" (Kogen). Their efforts resulted in the 1953 execution of the Rosenbergs.

Even still, "The Rosenbergs were both Jewish and traitors" argues Oliver Kamm in *The Jewish Chronicle*. Ethel Rosenberg, the first woman executed by the U.S. government since 1865 (Jenkins and Britannica Editors), had "devoted her life to serving Stalin" (Kamm) and her husband, Julius, was "confirmed" to have traded secrets "in the early 1990s after the collapse of the Soviet Union and the release of Soviet intelligence information" (Jenkins and Britannica Editors). This event and the specter of antisemitism that surrounded it is significant for its proximity to the release of *The King and I* in 1951, and *Flower Drum Song* in 1958, just five years after the execution of the Rosenbergs.

In a vacuum, it could be inferred that Rodgers and Hammerstein intentionally set out to employ stereotypes for laughs. But life is not a vacuum and the circumstances – political and social – surrounding Rodgers and Hammerstein during their productions of these "Oriental" musicals likely influenced their writing. It is reasonable to conclude that in avoiding accusations of communism themselves, they may have inadvertently played up racial stereotypes, despite attempting to promote a message of antiracism. Were it not for the political scent in the air, so-to-speak, Rodgers and Hammerstein may have acted differently as Baron's mall going do-gooders. But for circumstances governing their lives, this legacy of racism, one might conclude, was nearly theirs.

Lessons from the Other Generation

The Amazon Prime Video version of *Flower Drum Song* begins with a notice:

> WE … RECOGNIZE THAT THIS MUSICAL PORTRAYS THE CHINESE AMERICAN COMMUNITY THROUGH THE LENS OF ITS WHITE ADAPTERS, REINFORCING STEREOTYPES AND TROPES WHICH CAN BE PATRONIZING AT BEST, RACIST AT THEIR WORST (*Flower Drum Song*).

One scene from *Flower Drum Song* illustrates the essence of this notice in the context of containment and integration. In the scene, the main character, Wang Ta educates his father, Wang Chi-Yang about Western courting customs. When Chi-Yang volunteers that he has picked out a wife for his son, Wang Ta informs his father, "they don't do things like that over here. Here, a man picks out his own wife" and he turns and leaves as his father shouts for him to stop (*Flower Drum Song*, 23:00-23:20). After his son departs, Chi-Yang laments to his sister-in law, Madame Liang, that his children do not seek his consent before they act, which earns him another lesson: "This is the U.S.A. In my citizenship class, I have learned, 'We the People of the United States, are entitled to life, liberty and the pursuit of happy times.'" Displeased with this lesson, Chi-Yang shouts, "And the parents are entitled to pay the bills!" (*Flower Drum Song*, 23:41-24:19). Chi-Yang is portrayed as anachronistic, if not culturally archaic by enforcing norms from his native China on his children, and is in need of constant reminder that he is in America, not China.

Immediately following the education session is the song "The Other Generation." The song is a lament about leaving behind old customs. "A very discouraging problem is the other generation; they want to lead a life that's all their own" croons Chi-Yang. The scene transitions to Chi-Yang's younger son, Wang Sang, continuing the lament, who wonders "What are we going to do about the other generation? How will we ever communicate without communication, when we are using words the modern way?" (*Flower Drum Song*, 24:23-25:40). Similar to the intergenerational tension on display in *Flower Drum Song*, the notice at the beginning of the film is like the modern generation looking back and wondering what it is going to do. The film traffics in stereotypes and racism to entertain white audiences of the day. The

lesson learned by Wang Sang is that "the kids are simply stuck with that they got" (25:55-26:02). But what is the lesson imparted by Rogers and Hammerstein on their audiences?

Journalist Andrew Breitbart famously declared "Politics is downstream of culture" (as cited in Rothschild). However, the evidence here suggests that the "Oriental trio" of plays by Rodgers and Hammerstein was as much a product of politics as the culture that produced them. As laid out by Klein, *South Pacific*, *The King and I*, and *Flower Drum Song* were produced at a time when U.S. policy attempted to both contain and integrate Asia. The result was the portrayal of Asian Americans as dangerous enough to require separation from whites but exotic enough to tempt intrigue, up to the point of near misses with miscegenation. Even European characters had to be vetted for their American *bona fides*, otherwise the play writes might be accused of perpetuating communism at home. Containment further meant portraying Asian women as hyper sexualized and exotic. More broadly, Rodgers and Hammerstein used white characters to educate Asian characters in the ways of the West to civilize them. In *Flower Drum Song*, they used non-white but enculturated characters to educate their archaic immigrant peers.

In the decades since Rodgers and Hammerstein's "Oriental trio" of plays, many of these stereotypes have evolved while others persist. For instance, in 1966 William Petersen, writing for *The New York Times*, praised Japanese Americans for their embrace of American culture, declaring them a "success story" in contrast to "Negroes" and "Jews." That same year, *U.S. News and World Report* commended Chinese-Americans for teaching their young to "depend on their own efforts – not a welfare check – in order to reach America's 'promised land'" and concluded that "this remarkable group of Americans" faced "prejudice" and "hardship" that would "shock those now complaining about the hardships endured by today's Negroes" ("Success Story of One Minority Group in U.S."). These articles are examples of Klein's

middlebrow intellectual whose role it was to characterize the lives of minorities in ways their white audiences could understand.

There are echoes of *The King and I* in these articles as well. A group of Asians are brought out of barbarism into the good graces of the West through Anna's teachings. It is also evident in the way Madame Liang educated Chi-Yang about how things are done in America. Decades later, Asian Americans are still presented as the "model minority" in magazines (Lee and Joo). Studies have also shown that Asian Americans are portrayed as the "model minority" in television (Taylor and Stern; Ramasubramanian).

Though Rodgers and Hammerstein may not have built the stereotype sandcastle, they played in the sandbox. The popularity of their "Oriental" plays undoubtedly contributed to the perpetuation of stereotypes of the hyper-sexualized Asian woman and Asians as the model minority. There is also no doubt that Rodgers and Hammerstein were influenced by foreign policy prescriptions of containment and integration and may have inadvertently played up stereotypes in musicals intended to convey antiracist messaging in order to avoid accusations of communism. A historical review suggests the environment in which they were immersed back in the 40s and 50s contained a bad odor (communism) that was associated with Jews, which Rodgers and Hammerstein were. That odor may have had an inverse effect to the sweet smell of Mrs. Fields Cookies did on Baron's mallgoers. Whatever the reason, according to the notice preceding *Flower Drum Song* on Amazon Prime Video, the lesson from the other generation is that even antiracist messages can still perpetuate harmful stereotypes.

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